our clothes. Whatever you had—pen, spare clothes, ornaments—we had to deposit at the prison office before moving to the cell.

But this inspection, I was told, was a serious matter. Jail breaks and attacks were not rare in Kerala prisons. There have been tales of prisoners attacking each other or jail staff; a few making good their escape by tunneling their way to the yard and scaling the wall using a rope made of prison clothes. In most of these cases, it was an open secret, there was an insider hand.

In my cell, too, once in every three days a staff came and looked around. One day I asked him in half jest if I can help him get what he was searching for.

'Yeah,' he smirked. 'It will be helpful if you can get me a knife or some poison.'

I stopped joking with these guys after Sivanandan told me the dark side of these inspections. If a prisoner played too smart, the inspectors played dirty by planting marijuana in their cells. They would soon 'retrieve' or 'seize' the contraband and make a case against the prisoner.

This tool of blackmail worked with brutal efficiency against convicts at the fag end of their sentence. Getting caught with marijuana and facing another trial under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act of 1985 would significantly prolong their release. Some like Antony were nice with the prison staff, some others like Ripper cared two hoots.

Sasi was horrified every time the inspection happened. But I realised that his fear was not totally without reason. I told him not to panic since we neither had anything to hide nor we were at loggerheads with the prison officials. And anyway, a narcotics case would do no bigger harm.

If the case against us stood, we could be sentenced to fourteen years in jail for breach of the Official Secrets Act. A ganja case would have a much lesser sentence that would run concurrently.

'A spy who peddles marijuana sounds heady,' I joked.

Sasi, however, had his reasons to be scared. The investigators had already filed a second case against Sasi, with the rest of us as the co-accused, to keep us in custody even if we got bail in the ISRO spy case.